

AS A CORN WAS TO ITS HUSK, Joseph was to a walking stick, one he could uncomfortably lurch with. The young boy grew up without school, so advertently, he handled hauling a sack of leaf-packaged rice. People said it was ironic that a one-legged boy would take the work of walking. It ached him a little to hear, but way more things felt worse.

He was walking on the pr pavement beside the farm. Hectares of corn fields covered the world, colored green and gold, pollen flying over the canopy. The breeze—soft, slightly sweet to the taste—blew the maize to the side, carresing the air with rustling leaves.

The sun had travelled four fingers from the skyline, he measured; it was about time for breakfast. It just crossed his mind that, among his family, he'd been the only one prohibited from treading the farms. Everyone was normal except him, so it was ordinary to think they handed him this work for that reason.

It seemed too much to be a coincidence.

Joseph encountered some rustling behind the corn. He frowned; strangers mustn't roam around his family's field, and neither should his siblings wander this far, lest they get scolded by Mother. He stood at the tip of his feet and peeked over the rich field. And as he suspected, a hat appeared over the canopy, roaming between the maize. A farmer's hat.

Joseph grew suspicious (but curious!). He urged knowing which of his siblings was sneaking out this far in the fields

again, but he had to be quiet. Once they knew he was present, there was no catching up.

He stopped himself. People were waiting patiently for him with empty stomachs. He'd already been two minutes late. And if he tripped and fell onto the dirt, evidence that he may have been running through the fields would be all over him. He gazed left, then back over the fields.

The thrill flushed through his head. The surging energy pushed Joseph to drop the sack—an immense weight off his arm—and hobbled straight onto the soil. He had to know. He *had* to know.

He reached the stalks without falling, then slipped himself right in between as husks brushed his hair.

He was the only one in his family to fit right through.

A gap of light between the stems led his eyes towards the figure walking away, their back facing him. But something halted him. The cursed stick wouldn't pull free; it got stuck crossing a stalk. And the figure was walking further and further away from him.

"Stupid stick!" he bristled. His skin was getting itchy from bites and pointy stems. So, he let go of the stick, but that meant he stopped *clinging* to it. The weight tipped him forward. Losing balance, he clutched the surrounding stems, but they weren't strong enough.

He flew forward, plunging out of the corn and into the sunshine. He glanced at the farmer who was walking away ... and found a tail poking out of the dress' back.

He slammed into the dirt, which shook his vision and hearing.

“Joseph!” a blurred vision of her said, cowering back. “You scared me to death! Why would you—” She stopped at her tongue, taking off her hat and ducking a little while surveying the area.

Joseph recovered from the haze, but found it difficult to get up from the ground. The girl who was standing there—he recognized through the face and her stature—was Daisy, a lanky, yellow-haired girl in a blue light dress. His sister was a few years ahead of him, not only in age but in everything else.

She lowered herself to help him to his feet. “Are you okay?”

Joseph still felt sick. As Daisy held him upright, he tried peeking over to catch her tail. It wasn’t there. He had been hallucinating.

“Joseph. Answer me,” she said, patting the dirt off his shoulder. Color rose to her cheeks, and she gave him a worried look. “Where’s your stick?” Then, with a quick glance towards the sun to measure the time, she asked, “Where is food? You’re supposed to be heading to the farmhouse with it.”

A haunting realization washed over him. He had left the sack in the middle of the street. Joseph escaped Daisy’s hands and weakly began hopping back. He squeezed through the stalks of corn, which covered himself in grazes, jumped the upward incline to the street. He glanced left and right without a sight of the sack, except a horse carriage in the distance, going the opposite way from the farmhouse.

Nothing but dread and silence. His thoughts slipped back into his body with distraught and a revelation. He felt sick, but it all made sense now.

Footsteps crunched the grass behind him, then a hard step on the concrete road. “Joseph?” he heard her call.

Joseph turned around, meeting her gaze as his own eyes watered. “You had a tail.”

“N—No, I hadn’t.”

“I saw it!” Joseph limped towards her, fueled with anger. “I’m running around with a missing foot, and you get to have a tail?!”

He hobbled forward under pure exhaustion, the grazes and blows suddenly hoarding him with pain. The easy steps completely labored him. She could just gently step back, and he’d never reach her.

The Almighty had cursed his life. He was the forgotten shelf in the attic, dusted and webbed, except that shelf leached off of the family’s food and money, serving as nothing but weight. Joseph kept limping forward, determined to *do something* for once.

But he tripped and fell.

For a moment, he lost grasp of reality. It was comfortable this way, curling up on the pavement. He wanted to vanish. Daisy was probably running back towards the farmhouse, ready to tell on him to Mother. He sighed his remaining energy away. Powerless, he gave up.

“Joseph?” Daisy said, caressing his hair. The touch brought him back to life, and to the cold sensation on his knee that was bleeding. He raised his cheek from the ground, but ... he dropped it back.

So he just looked upwards and saw that it was a tail brushing him—a long one with a prominent dark tuft of hair at the tip—as if she’d taken one from a lion. No, she’d stolen it from him.

“Joseph,” her soft voice letting through his ear without permission. “You’re right. I had a tail.”

He shrank smaller. Daisy held him on the shoulder and lifted him until he sat upright. His body was in shambles.

His sister raised his chin to her face of rosy cheeks and a warm look. Her dress smelled of cinnamon. “You’re in pain. You’re reminded all the time that you’re still disabled.” Joseph drops his chin. “But that’s because you’re the only one who’s brave enough to show it.”

It took a while to understand. “What do you mean?” Joseph mumbled.

“Please never tell Mother about anything I’m about to show you.” She swallowed, kneeling beside him. “We are all different. We use dresses, garments, and we paint our faces to escape from our broken bodies. But you, Joseph, you don’t care about hiding it. You refused to wear any kind of clothing.”

“You’re wrong,” Joseph said, though unsure himself. “I just ... I just don’t want to be hot and sweaty all day.”

Daisy smiled. “Having a tail might sound like a good thing, but that’s because you haven’t understood my body completely.” She used one hand to unwrap the cowl around her neck and tossed it to the ground. She used one hand to pull her dress down from her shoulder, which exposed her chemise. Joseph flinched, but Daisy insisted on his full attention.

It only occurred to him now ... that she’d only had one hand out. Where was her other one?

“I have a tail, so it frees up one hand to do more important business.” Joseph looked closely; her left hand was pressing into an inward curve of her clothing under her left breast—slowly, rhythmically, as if was a *heart beating*—as mesmerizing as the heart itself.

She didn’t have a heart.

What would happen if she stopped pressing? Would she die? Suffocate? A cold chill slithered down his back.

A moment passed, and Daisy pulled her dress back together, again with just one hand. “Every night I pray that my hand keeps beating. I think I’ve engraved it in its muscle so much, it just moves by itself now.”

Joseph brushed his own chest, feeling his own heart intact and beating. He couldn’t imagine having to press it manually against himself ... for months without end.

As he watched his sister rise, he firmly engraved in his mind how her garments flawlessly wrap around her and conceal her deepest, darkest secret.

She looked down to him. “We’ll lie to mother that a passerby had snatched it from you. Maybe she’ll start assigning Sarah to bring food instead.” She kneeled down and offered him a piggyback, which Joseph accepted. up, she carried his weight easily. “And don’t tell her I wandered this far, okay?”

The blood on his knee seeped onto her dress.

“So you were just hiding from them,” he said as his sister began walking, “because you wanted to use your tail once in a while.”

His sister was quiet.

“You’re pretty smart.”